# Policy & Strategy Lab

## Participant Handbook

Welcome to the Lab. Over twenty days you will take one real Indian public problem from a vague concern to a recommendation you can defend in front of a decision-making panel. This handbook explains how the programme works, what is expected of you and what to do before Day 1.

## 1. What the Lab is, and is not

The Lab teaches structured problem-solving, of the kind used in consulting, applied to Indian public policy with the institutional and political seriousness that public problems need.

It is not case-interview preparation, a survey of policy theory, a research methods course or training in one firm's proprietary method. Four weeks will not make you a consultant or a sector expert. They should make you a capable junior analyst on a scoped problem: someone who can take an unfamiliar issue, structure it, find and judge the evidence, compare options and recommend what a named decision-maker should do, saying honestly what the evidence does and does not show.

## 2. How it works

| Element | What it means for you |
|---|---|
| One case | You choose an Indian public problem and work on it for all twenty days. Every worksheet builds part of your final report. |
| One method | Everyone learns the same tools. Each day has one anchor tool, demonstrated on a running case, then applied to your own case. |
| The spine case | The instructor demonstrates every tool on Madhyapur, a stylised city with a household waste problem. Its figures are illustrative. |
| Pods | You work in a pod of four, each member with a different case. You challenge each other's work every week. |
| Four gates | On Days 5, 10, 15 and 19 you submit your work for detailed feedback, then revise. |
| A decision, not an essay | You finish with a client report to a named decision-maker, a five-slide pitch and an individual defence. |

**The method.** Weeks 1 to 3 follow the seven steps of structured problem-solving: define, disaggregate, prioritise, plan the work, analyse, synthesise, communicate. Week 4 adds the policy analyst's steps for choosing between options: alternatives, criteria, outcomes, trade-offs, decision and story.

**Three reality tests.** Every recommendation is tested against who has the legal authority to act, where the money comes from, and what frontline workers will actually do. The state is not a firm.

## 3. A typical day

| Minutes | What happens |
|---|---|
| 0 to 10 | An opening problem to think about straight away |

| Minutes | What happens |
|---|---|
| 10 to 35 | One concept |
| 35 to 55 | A demonstration of the day's tool on the Madhyapur case |
| 55 to 90 | A group activity on a common case |
| 90 to 110 | You apply the tool to your own case in your workbook |
| 110 to 120 | Debrief and a one-line exit task |

Thursdays run a longer challenge: a simulation, a hypothesis battle or a red team. Gate days include 40 minutes of pod peer review. Days 11 to 13 are research studios.

## 4. The four weeks

| Week | Theme | You finish the week with |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Define and structure | A problem diagnostic: a precise problem, an issue tree, a problem tree and a feedback loop (Gate 1) |
| 2 | Situate and prioritise | The institutions, money and actors around your problem; testable hypotheses; a workplan (Gate 2) |
| 3 | Investigate and synthesise | An evidence register, analysis and a two-page diagnostic memo (Gate 3) |
| 4 | Decide, deliver, defend | Options appraised, a delivery plan, indicators and a pitch (Gate 4); the defence on Day 20 |

The Course Calendar lists every day's topic, output and independent work.

## 5. Your pod and its roles

Four roles rotate every week.

| Role | What you do |
|---|---|
| Chair | Keep time; make sure every case gets attention |
| Sceptic | Challenge at least one claim in every case, every pod session |
| Evidence checker | Ask how do you know? and check one source per case |
| Scribe | Record challenges, responses and changes in the pod log |

Your pod contribution and peer reviews are worth 10 per cent of the marks. Challenge is quality control, not a personal attack.

## 6. Habits the Lab asks of you

- **The Analyst's Ledger.** Tag every substantive claim as fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.
- **The sealed answer.** On Day 3 you write your best answer to your problem in 100 words and seal it. You open it on Day 20 and explain what changed.
- **Disconfirming evidence first.** For every hypothesis, write what would prove it wrong before you look for support.
- **Answer first.** In memos, slides and the defence, lead with the conclusion.

- **Revise.** Respond to feedback at every gate and record what you changed. Revision is credited.

## 7. Workload

| Element | Hours |
|---|---|
| Before Day 1 | 3 to 4 |
| Live sessions | 40 (two hours a day, Monday to Friday) |
| Independent work | About 14 (about 45 minutes on most days) |
| Final report after Day 20 | 6 to 8 |
| Total | About 63 to 66 |

That is roughly 13 to 14 hours a week during the four weeks. It is demanding if you are also working full time; plan for it.

## 8. Assessment in brief

| Component | Weight |
|---|---|
| Workbook portfolio | 35% |
| Evidence register | 15% |
| Pod contribution and peer review | 10% |
| Client report | 20% |
| Presentation and defence (individual 15%, pod synthesis 5%) | 20% |

Gates give feedback; the portfolio is marked once at the end, with credit for documented revision. Everything except the pod synthesis is assessed individually. Full rubrics are in the Assessment Handbook.

## 9. Choosing your case

A good case is a specific problem, in one place, with a named decision-maker who faces a real decision, and with public evidence you can reach in four weeks. Poverty in India is a field of study, not a case. Climb the ladder until a decision appears:

| Rung | Example |
|---|---|
| Domain | Education |
| Issue | Foundational learning |
| Problem | Low reading levels at the end of Grade 3 |
| Population | Children in government primary schools |
| Place | One named district |
| Institution | The state school education department and the district office |
| Decision | What the District Education Officer should change in teacher support next year |

Your case must pass five quick tests: it is specific; evidence exists (you have opened two public data sources and one published qualitative source); someone can act; it is manageable in four weeks; and it is safe (no primary data, no personal data, analysable without taking a party-political position). The full feasibility rubric is in the Assessment Handbook.

## 10. Rules you must follow

**No primary research.** All evidence comes from published and publicly available sources. You will not interview, survey or observe anyone for your case.

**AI tools.** You may use them to suggest structures and rival explanations, critique your drafts and improve your writing. You may not use AI output as evidence. Every fact, figure, citation and description of an institution must come from a source you have read and checked. AI tools invent plausible citations; an unverified citation is treated as an error. Disclose any AI use at every gate.

**Integrity and norms.** Your analysis and writing must be your own. Analyse institutions and incentives, not individuals; do not blame named officials. Stay non-partisan. Where a matter is before a court, analyse the policy questions without commenting on the merits.

## 11. Before Day 1

| When | Task | Time |
|---|---|---|
| Seven days before | Send three candidate problems, one paragraph each | 1 hour |
| Five days before | Complete the entry diagnostic: read a short case and write a problem statement, five questions and one recommendation | 45 minutes |
| Before Day 1 | Spreadsheet primer (below) | 60 to 90 minutes |
| Three days before | Read the instructor's comments on your candidates | 15 minutes |

**Spreadsheet primer: what you should be able to do by Day 1.** Open a CSV file; sort and filter a table; write a formula that refers to other cells; compute a share and a percentage-point change; build a pivot table that summarises by category; make a bar chart with a title and labelled axes. Google Sheets or Microsoft Excel are both fine.

## 12. Where to find things

| Folder | Contents |
|---|---|
| 02 Curriculum and Calendar | The detailed curriculum and the course calendar |
| 03 Slides | The slides for each day, as PowerPoint and PDF |
| 05 Workbooks | Your ten workbooks, as Word and PDF |
| 07 Assessment | The Assessment Handbook, with rubrics and forms |
| 08 Capstone | The Capstone Guide |
| 09 Participant Handbook and Readings | This handbook and the reading list |